

» VOLES, LEMMINGS, AND MUSKRATS



7–12 cm
2¾–4¾ in

relatively long tail

STRIPED DWARF HAMSTER

Cricetulus barabensis

By raiding crops to gather seeds and grain, this rodent can become a serious pest in farming areas. Farmers destroy its burrows while ploughing.



6–8 cm
2¼–3¼ in

ROBOROVSKI'S DESERT HAMSTER

Phodopus roborovskii

From the dry grasslands of C. Asia, this tiny animal is popular as a pet. During the breeding season, it can produce three to four litters.



17–32 cm
6½–12½ in

COMMON HAMSTER

Cricetus cricetus

This burrowing species lives alone and hibernates underground through the winter. Its burrows may contain up to 65 kg (145 lb) of stored food.



golden orange fur

12–17 cm
4¾–6½ in

LONG-HAIRED GOLDEN HAMSTER

Mesocricetus auratus

The golden hamster has been selectively bred to create exotic forms, such as this albino variety, that would not survive in the wild.



12–17 cm
4¾–6½ in

GOLDEN HAMSTER

Mesocricetus auratus

Originally from Syria, where it is now an endangered species, this hamster has become a favourite household pet in Europe and N. America.

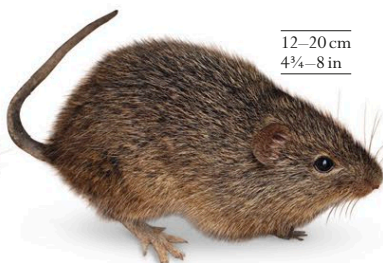


9–11 cm
3½–4¼ in

WHITE-FOOTED MOUSE

Peromyscus leucopus

A very common and adaptable creature, this deer mouse inhabits almost every type of land habitat in central and the E. USA.



12–20 cm
4¾–8 in

HISPID COTTON RAT

Sigmodon hispidus

This short-lived, surface-dwelling herbivore occurs in grassland habitats in the S. USA and Mexico.

MICE, RATS, AND RELATIVES

One fifth of all mammal species belong to this huge family. The Muridae are distributed almost worldwide, including the polar regions. Some species carry serious diseases, and others are significant agricultural pests. However, several are used in medical research and are commonly kept as pets.



10–12 cm
4–4¾ in

NORTHEAST AFRICAN SPINY MOUSE

Acomys cahirinus

Like other spiny mice, this rodent has stiffened hairs on its body for protection and very thin skin, which permits easy cooling in its hot, dry habitat.



8–13 cm
3¼–5 in

ARABIAN SPINY MOUSE

Acomys dimidiatus

This mouse was previously considered the same species as the N.E. African one, except that it occurs east of the Red Sea.



9–14 cm
3½–5½ in

MONGOLIAN JIRD

Meriones unguiculatus

In the wild, this gerbil lives in the dry steppes of C. Asia, forming large social groups. Many are now kept as pets.



9–13 cm
3½–5 in

PALLID GERBIL

Gerbillus floweri

Like most small desert rodents, this gerbil has a pale body. It is widespread in N. Africa and the Middle East, where its coloration provides good camouflage.



10–13 cm
4–5 in

FAT-TAILED JIRD

Pachyuromys duprasi

Like many small, desert-living mammals, this species stores fat in its tail. The tail has no fur, allowing it to radiate excess body heat.

